

Recuperation and Entertainment

For US troops with only letters from loved ones to remind them of home, the long months and often tough conditions in Vietnam took a toll on morale. Periods of relaxation, especially out of the country, were therefore eagerly anticipated.

◀◀ BEFORE

During World War II and the Korean War, a combination of censorship, propaganda, movies, and entertainment tours kept up troop morale.

THE USO

Prior to the Vietnam War, logistical restrictions meant that travel outside the war zone for **rest and relaxation** (R&R) was rare. The nonprofit United Service Organization (USO) arranged **troop entertainment**, including live appearances by top stars such as Rita Hayworth (World War II) and Marilyn Monroe (Korea).

Life in the war zone meant acute hardships that over time dampened soldier morale. High heat and humidity, endless rain and mud, biting insects, and, for combat troops, the anxieties and danger of battle all took their toll. There were also long working hours, relentless military discipline, and limited opportunities for privacy or individuality. Mail provided the only contact with friends and family back home, and loneliness and homesickness were rife. Like antiwar demonstrators back in the United States, many service personnel questioned the war's ethics and necessity, and whether it could even be won.

Leisure facilities

Low morale could lead to indiscipline, absenteeism, drug abuse, and other subversive behavior that threatened discipline and mission readiness. To counter the problem, the US military equipped bases with an array of leisure amenities to occupy the troops. Most bases within the war zone had ball courts, while larger bases had swimming pools, and a few even had golf courses, go-cart tracks, and bowling alleys. Some bases had education centers, arts and crafts workshops, libraries, movie theaters, and performance spaces.

Celebrity visits

Live entertainment was also provided. Although the United Service Organization (USO) arranged celebrity-studded tours from time to time, most of the civilian acts that toured the military bases were unknown entertainers flown in from Asia and Australia. For bases that were too dangerous for civilian entertainers to visit, the Army's Special Services Division dispatched Command Military Touring Shows composed of GI musicians on temporary duty. A few bases even had their own theater companies.

By the late 1960s, there were hundreds of acts touring the war zone at any given time, and the US Army in South Vietnam was effectively the largest promoter of live entertainment in the world.

■ **3,200** The number of performers, from 26 countries, touring the Vietnam circuit in 1970.